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Technology Drives Us

Apple to aim at electronics test solutions

You may be surprised, Apple is planning to come up with Mac Test, an engineering workstation in a laptop form for test engineers. Apart from USB and LAN, it will include PCI Express ports for interfacing with PXI or AXIe systems. But it is the software that has everybody talking. When an engineer transitions from Windows environment to Mac Test, the current engineering documents and test procedures would be converted to an Apple proprietary format, deleted from their current folders, and then loaded into iTunes, as reported in an article in *EDN*.

Digitizer U5309A. At the heart of the U5309A is a data processing unit (DPU) based on Xilinx Virtex-6 FPGA. Responsible for supervising the module functionality, data flow and real-time signal processing, this powerful FPGA allows data storage and reduction to be carried out at the digitiser level, speeding-up analysis and minimising transfer volumes.

An end user of an instrument with an 'open' FPGA can fully personalise the functionality of the instrument by adding application-specific measurements, custom triggering or the capability to use new digital protocols onto the system, to name a few. Essentially, the user can tweak firmware of the device to meet requirements—not just defining in software how the data should be used but also adding new functionalities that the instrument can perform. Using this approach boosts test speed.

The FPGA in Keysight's Digitizer is primarily intended to open the design of the FPGA to specific user requirements by providing a development framework that interfaces to the underlying hardware. It mainly looks to achieve multi GS/s real-time processing on a full digitiser framework by leveraging full density and speed of the FPGA. It also boosts the time-to-market with turn-key, easy-to-use development flow and debug.

Cloud-connected and voice-controlled instruments

Engineers have been transferring data between their devices using USB drives or a network, but now it's possible to do so with cloud technologies. Besides storing files in the cloud, some services host full applications in the cloud.

"Instrumentation that incorporates

network and cloud connectivity could provide these same benefits to engineers. Both the data and user interface could be accessed by multiple engineers from anywhere in the world," says Misra. He adds, "When debugging an issue with a colleague who is off site, rather than only sharing a static screenshot, engineers could interact with the instrument in real time to better understand the issue. Cloud technologies could greatly improve an engineering team's efficiency and productivity."

Also, context-aware computing is beginning to emerge and could fundamentally change how we interact with devices. This technology uses situational and environmental information to anticipate users' needs and deliver situation-aware content, features and experiences. A popular example of this is Siri, a feature found in recent Apple iOS devices.

Similar intelligence when combined with instrumentation could be game-changing. A common challenge that engineers face is attempting to make configuration changes to an instrument at the same time that their hands are tied up with probes. Misra says, "Voice control could not only provide hands-free interaction but also easier interaction with features. In addition, predictive intelligence could be used to highlight relevant or interesting data. An oscilloscope could automatically zoom and configure based on an interesting part of a signal, or it could add relevant measurements based on signal shape." "An instrument that leverages mobile devices could integrate and take advantage of context-aware computing as the technology is developed." ●

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